



Neighbourhood Woes

DELHI Red terror seems to be the biggest worry for the UPA Government these days. While they are faced with the Left's ultimatum on the Indo-US nuclear deal at home, Nepal's Maoist terror is giving sleepless nights to many in Delhi. On September 18, the Maoists pulled out of the eight-party G.P. Koirala Government that was already running on ventilator support. They have now threatened to launch a mass agitation which may take the country to the brink of a crisis

yet again and pose a serious security threat for India.

The crisis was triggered off after Maoist supremo Prachanda's demand for the abolition of monarchy in Nepal and the installation of an electoral system based on proportional representation for the elections to the constituent assembly this November was rejected by the Koirala Government.

Last week as the situation worsened, India dispatched Foreign

RED RAGE: Nepal is on the boil again

Secretary Shiv Shankar Menon to Kathmandu to diffuse the tension, asking them to be patient and not to rock the Government. But the plea had little effect on the Maoists.

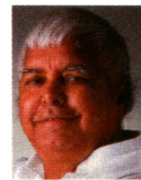
India is concerned as it shares a 1,751-km-long open border with Nepal, and it fears large scale immigration from its neighbour if the situation worsens. Another worry is the intelligence inputs that Pakistan's intelligence agency ISI is redoubling its efforts to mount anti-India activities from Nepal. The mountain kingdom has become an easy destination to source explosives and arms and smuggle them into India.

As the fragile peace process runs the risk of being punctured, the Home Ministry has asked all border states to increase the vigil and beef up security. But while South Block is shying away from direct involvement for the time being, they have no solution in sight to tackle the 'red terror'. **by Saurabh Shukla**

SIGNPOSTS

ELECTED: Rajya Sabha member **Arjun Sengupta**, as chairman of the Inter-governmental Working Group of the Human Rights Council on the right to development.

ARRESTED: **Prabal Neog**, commandant of the banned militant outfit United Liberation Front of Asom's 28 Battalion, near Tezpur in Assam.



SUMMONED: Union Railway Minister **Lalu Prasad Yadav** by a special CBI

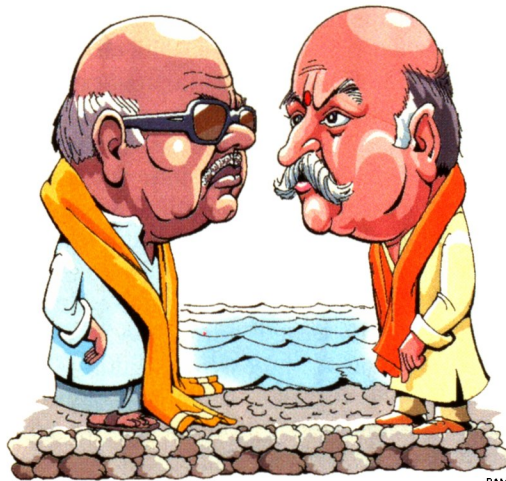
court in Ranchi in a fresh case of fodder scam. He is already facing charges in five other cases.

APPOINTED: **P. J. Thomas**, a 1973-batch IAS officer, as chief secretary of Kerala. He is at present principal secretary, higher education and replaces Lizzie Jacob.

WON: By **East Bengal**, the Federation Cup, beating Mahindra United 2-1 in Ludhiana.

VIS-A-VIS **M. KARUNANIDHI** Tamil Nadu chief minister **versus** **PRAVIN TOGADIA** VHP general secretary

“Who is this **Ram**? In which engineering college did he study? When did he build this so-called bridge? Is there any evidence for this?”



“**Karunanidhi** as chief minister in **1971** had accepted the **Ram Sethu** bridge. If he goes back on the public document, he can be prosecuted.”

EPILOGUE: Politicians should stop sparring over a mythological bridge and build bridges of harmony.